

IN HUNTERSVILLE

Feathered visitor finds sanctuary at day care

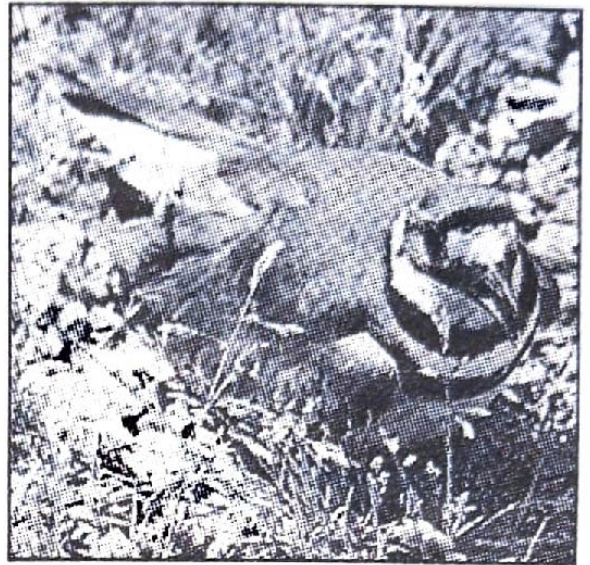
Killdeer builds nest in playground; teachers use event as a lesson

BY SHIRLEY HUNTER MOORE
Staff Writer

An unexpected feathered visitor flew into University Child Development Center last week and has given the teachers and children a close-up science lesson.

A killdeer, the peculiar-acting bird that nests on open ground, found a comfy place for itself and four speckled eggs on the playground near the sliding board. The day-care center's staffers say it's been entertaining to watch the bird's reaction whenever someone approaches.

It screeches loudly. It also



FILE PHOTO

A killdeer like this one is using the University Child Development Center's playground to raise her baby birds. The peculiar-acting bird often nests on open ground.

feigns having an injured wing to draw attention from the eggs. Once it feels the young are safe, the bird suddenly appears healed.

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Betty O'Leary, a rehabilitation assistant at the Carolina Raptor Center near Huntersville, said federal law prohibits harming native birds, their nests or their eggs.

So moving the eggs wouldn't have been a good option. The day-care center, off Northcross Drive, has sectioned off a small area around the killdeer and the eggs.

Teachers allow the children to view the bird without getting too close.

It's almost fitting that the bird would choose a day-care center for nesting, because her actions "make me think about a mother protecting her children," said Kim McGriff, assistant director at the

day-care center.

The killdeer is fairly common, but it doesn't usually nest in an area with a lot of human activity, O'Leary said.

The bird's choice might have something to do with the gray-colored mulch on the playground, she said.

Because of the bird's similar

gray-and-white coloring, the mulch camouflages it and helps protect it from prey.

It'll probably will be several more days before the eggs hatch, McGriff said.

"I don't know what we're going to do when she's gone, because that's been the topic of conversation around here," she added.

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